

Psalms 48

Great Is the Lord

Great is the Lord... in the city of our God
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 • THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised in the city of our God, in the mountain of his holiness.*
- 2 *Beautiful for situation, the joy of the whole earth, is mount Zion, on the sides of the north, the city of the great King.*
- 3 *God is known in her palaces for a refuge.*
- 4 *For, lo, the kings were assembled, they passed by together.*
- 5 *They saw it, and so they marvelled; they were troubled, and hasted away.*
- 6 *Fear took hold upon them there, and pain, as of a woman in travail.*
- 7 *Thou breakest the ships of Tarshish with an east wind.*
- 8 *As we have heard, so have we seen in the city of the LORD of hosts, in the city of our God: God will establish it for ever. Selah.*
- 9 *We have thought of thy lovingkindness, O God, in the midst of thy temple.*
- 10 *According to thy name, O God, so is thy praise unto the ends of the earth: thy right hand is full of righteousness.*
- 11 *Let mount Zion rejoice, let the daughters of Judah be glad, because of thy judgments.*
- 12 *Walk about Zion, and go round about her: tell the towers thereof.*
- 13 *Mark ye well her bulwarks, consider her palaces; that ye may tell it to the generation following.*
- 14 *For this God is our God for ever and ever: he will be our guide even unto death.*

2 • CONTEXT

Psalms 48 is a Zion hymn praising the beauty and security of the city of God, recounting how allied kings who came against her were struck with fear and fled, broken like ships in a storm, purely by witnessing what God had already established. It then invites worshipers to physically walk about Zion, count her towers, and carry the report to future generations, because “this God is our God for ever and ever.” Henry reads it as praise rooted in observed, remembered acts of deliverance rather than abstract theology alone.

3 • VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

Great is the Lord, greatly to be praised in the city of God, His holy mountain—beautiful in its setting, the joy of the whole earth, Mount Zion, the city of the great King, where God is known in her palaces as a refuge.

Verse 4-8

Kings assembled and advanced together against the city, but when they saw it they marveled, were troubled, and hastened away; fear took hold of them, pain as of a woman in labor, broken by an east wind like ships of Tarshish. As they had heard, so they saw—God establishes this city forever.

Verse 9-11

Worshipers have thought on God’s lovingkindness in the midst of His temple; praise matches His name, righteousness fills His right hand; Mount Zion and the daughters of Judah rejoice because of His judgments.

Verse 12-14

A call to walk about Zion, go around her, count her towers, mark well her bulwarks, and consider her palaces, so as to tell it to the generation following: “This God is our God for ever and ever: he will be our guide even unto death.”

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

God’s past acts of deliverance are meant to be deliberately observed, remembered, and passed on—not left as vague sentiment but told concretely to the next generation. Security ultimately rests not in the city’s walls themselves but in the God who established and defends them.

Application for life today.

Take time to literally recount, out loud or in writing, specific evidence of God’s faithfulness in your life or family history, following the psalm’s call to “tell it to the generation following.” When facing intimidating opposition, remember that fear can strike even powerful adversaries the moment they truly see what God has already secured. Let “this God is our God... he will be our guide even unto death” (v. 14) become a settled confession you return to in uncertain seasons.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What specific story of God’s faithfulness could you deliberately pass on to a younger person, as this psalm instructs?

2. Where do you need to trust that God has already “established” something securely, even though present threats look intimidating?

3. How does confessing “he will be our guide even unto death” (v. 14) change your outlook on your own mortality or long-term future?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).